

C37 — The 12-Month Plan, Readiness Checklist and Your First 90 Days

1. What interviewers test

"How have you prepared for this interview, and what did you learn about yourself?" "How do you keep up with this industry?" "How do you decide what to learn when there is too much?" "What would you do in your first 90 days?" Interviewers ask about preparation and ramp-up because they predict how you will learn on the job: whether you diagnose before you act, practice what you are weak at, use evidence, and turn learning into work that others can see. This chapter converts the whole book into a dated plan for one reader: someone who graduated in October 2024, has about two years in a product role, and has twelve months. It gives a baseline, a month-by-month plan with a reading map, a weekly cadence, projects that become interview stories, a literacy habit built on verified sources, a practice toolkit, a readiness gate, a fallback and, if you get the offer, a first-90-days plan.

Where it shows up. `Inferred`: behavioral and motivation questions about learning and growth, and the hiring-manager conversation about how you would start `[unverified: candidate-reported]`. It is also the working plan for everything else in this book.

What is scored. Whether your preparation and your ramp-up plan are specific, evidence-led and honest `Inferred`: a measured baseline, a plan driven by gaps, a feedback loop, a way to know you are ready, and a realistic first 90 days that ends in something shipped and written down.

Six observable behaviors:

1. You start from a measured baseline, not a feeling.
2. You allocate time by importance and gap, and re-measure on a schedule.
3. You practice by producing answers, and get outside scoring.
4. You turn work into stories with numbers that are true.
5. You decide when to apply by a written gate, not by anxiety or a calendar.
6. You plan the first 90 days around learning, relationships and one small shipped result.

The failure this prevents. Six patterns end preparation answers: "I've been reading a lot," a plan with no checkpoints, practicing the favorite round, applying to the top choice first, no fallback, and a first-90-days plan that is "meet everyone and learn the product."

Dates to check before you rely on this book. Several facts here carry dates that will pass during a twelve-month plan. They were checked in October 2026. Check each one again at its date, and treat anything marked as of 2026-10 the same way.

| What | Date in the book | Where | What to check | |---|---|---|---| | Google's 2027-start Associate Product Manager application window | Closed at the end of 6 October 2026, per Google's posting | C01.4, C33 | Whether the window moved, and when the next cycle opens; dates varied within the 2025 cycle | | Meta's Rotational Product Manager program | Open per Meta's posting of 23 September 2026 (March and September 2027 starts); the posting lists 4+ years of related experience as a minimum; no closing date found | C01.4, C33, C37 | The posting's eligibility line and closing date; whether eligibility changes again | | UPI merchant fee in India | 15 October 2026 | C09 | Whether the fee started as announced; accounts differ on who announced it | | NPCI's 30% cap on any one UPI app's share of volume | 31 December 2026, after two extensions | Appendix A.8 | Whether it takes effect or is extended again | | India's data protection rules | 13 November 2026 (consent managers) and 13 May 2027 (main obligations) | C09, C21, C25 | The phase dates | | EU AI Act | 2 December 2026 (marking by generative systems already on the market), 2 December 2027 and 2 August 2028 (high-risk systems) | C25 | The dates set by the 2026 amending regulation | | US state AI law | 1 January 2027, Colorado's narrower law on automated decision-making technology | C25 | Its status; no comprehensive federal AI statute was in force through July 2026 | | Program rules, loop formats and rules on AI tools in interviews | Any time | C01, C33 | Each company's careers page and interview guidance | | Prices, model names and product features | Any time | C20, C24, C25, C28 | Anything marked as of 2026-10 |

2. The concept from first principles

C37.1 Diagnostic baseline against the bands

You cannot plan from a feeling, and C34 showed why: fluency is not evidence (CS-C34-02). The baseline gives you numbers (FW-C37-01).

Step 1. Three recorded mocks, outside-scored. In your first two weeks, record three mock rounds of different types (for example product design, a metrics question and a behavioral story), and have an independent scorer rate each on the C34 scorecard (1 to 5, where 2 is Baseline, 4 is Strong and 5 is Standout) without hearing your own scores first. If you have no partner yet, score the recordings yourself a week later against the written anchors and treat the numbers as provisional; get an outside scorer as soon as you can.

Step 2. Map to the ten competencies. Average the scores by competency (C01.6): product sense, discovery, problem solving, analytics and experimentation, execution, technical fluency, AI product thinking, design and UX, strategy and go-to-market, behavioral and communication. Three mocks will not cover all ten; mark untested ones "unmeasured" and schedule a mock for each before the first checkpoint.

Step 3. Compute importance times gap. Use the importance weights in C01.6 (3 for high, 2 for medium), the gap as 5 minus your score, and allocate drill hours in proportion (FW-C01-04; Worked example 1).

Step 4. Record a calibration estimate. After six mocks with an outside scorer, compute your bias (mean self-score minus outside score) and your error (mean absolute difference) (FW-C34-03). A positive bias means you overrate yourself; subtract it from your self-scores until it shrinks.

Step 5. Set numeric targets and dates. For the two largest importance-times-gap dimensions, set a target (for example "analytics from 2.9 to 3.8 by the second checkpoint") and a re-score date.

What the baseline is not. It is not a verdict on whether you will get an offer; one outside scorer on three mocks is noisy, and the scores are the author's synthesis of observable behaviors, not any company's rubric `Original` `Inferred`.

C37.2 The twelve-month plan, month by month

Assumptions (adjust them to your life). About nine hours a week for 48 weeks (52 weeks minus four of rest or travel), so about 432 hours; a start in the first week of October 2026 and an end in the last week of September 2027; access to at least two practice partners from month 2; and the profile in C01 (about two years in a product role). If you have six hours a week, use the fast track in the reading map below; with twelve, add depth in your weakest area.

The hours budget (FW-C37-02).

Activity	Hours a week	Hours in the year	What it is
Reading and worked examples	2.0	96	First read of each chapter on your path, and recomputing its worked examples by hand
Timed drills	2.5	120	Exercises and questions answered aloud on the clock, allocated by importance times gap
Partner mocks and scoring	1.5	72	One scored mock a week with an outside scorer from month 2 (before that, recorded solo drills)
Projects that become stories	1.5	72	Work that produces true, numbered stories (C37.4)
Literacy habit	1.0	48	The weekly routine in C37.5
Journal and review	0.5	24	Error log, answer journal and the monthly re-score (C34.5)
Total	9.0	432	

Why it fits. The other 34 chapters of the book are about 637,000 words, which is about 53 hours of first reading at 200 words a minute (a planning estimate). Reading and recomputing the worked examples roughly doubles that, to about 106 hours, a little above the 96-hour reading budget; the difference is why the deep dives and the reference library are chosen by

need and not all read. Drills, mocks and projects are the rest of the year, and they are where most of the learning is. The word counts are those of the chapters when the book was written, and the hours follow from the rates stated here.

The reading map ([reading-map](#))

A **reading map** is a ranking of the chapters of this book into a core path, deep dives and a reference library, with the hours each costs, so that the book's length does not burden a reader on a twelve-month plan. Study hours are twice the first-read hours (read, then recompute the worked examples); the figures are planning estimates (invented rates, 200 words a minute). The reading map is the author's judgment of importance by interview weight (C01.6) [Original](#) [Inferred](#).

Track	Chapters	First read (h)	Study (h)	Use
Core path (21 chapters)	C01, C02, C03, C05, C06, C07, C08, C12, C13, C14, C15, C16, C17, C18, C21, C24, C25, C31, C32, C33, C34	34.6	69.3	Every reader
Deep dives (8 chapters)	C04 estimation, C09 new markets, C10 UX and quality, C11 critique method, C19 platforms, C20 go-to-market, C22 system design, C23 machine learning and ranking	12.2	24.4	By gap and by target company
Reference library (5 chapters)	C26 zero to one, C27 domain primers, C28 teardown library, C29 anti-patterns, C30 five journeys	6.3	12.5	Lookup, practice material and templates

The fast track (about 80 hours in all). For a reader with fewer weeks or hours: C01, C02, C03, C05, C07, C12, C13, C15, C16, C31, C32, C33 and C34 (13 chapters; about 21 hours of first reading and 43 of study), plus about 23 hours of timed drills, about 12 hours of partner mocks and about 4 hours of stories and journal. Add C24 for AI roles. The fast track covers the high-weight competencies; it leaves out depth.

Chapter-by-chapter hours by month (study hours; deep dives can be swapped by gap).

Month	Dates	Chapters	Study (h)
1	Oct 2026	C01, C02, C34 (sections 1 to 4)	6.4
2	Nov 2026	C03, C05, C31 (the story bank and signal sections)	8.2
3	Dec 2026	C06, C07, C32	10.3
4	Jan 2027	C12, C13, C04	10.3
5	Feb 2027	C14, C08, C11	10.1
6	Mar 2027	C15, C16, C17	9.5
7	Apr 2027	C18, C21, C22	9.9
8	May 2027	C24, C25, C23	9.8

Month	Dates	Chapters	Study (h)
9	Jun 2027	C31 (the rest), C33, C09	9.0
10	Jul 2027	C34 (the rest), C19, C20, C10	10.2
11	Aug 2027	The reference library, by need (C26 to C30)	12.5
12	Sep 2027	No new chapters; review and the final-week protocol	0
		Total	106.2

The plan, month by month (FW-C37-02)

Month	Focus	Deliverables	Checkpoint or gate
1 (Oct 2026)	Baseline and setup	Three outside-scored mocks; the baseline table; fit-checked postings (C01.5); the toolkit (C37.6); the literacy routine started; a first story-bank list of 10 episodes	Decide this week which, if any, October windows to use (see "Application waves")
2 (Nov 2026)	Foundations: structure and metrics	Two partners recruited; weekly mocks begin; sandbox set up and first funnel query; first project chosen	Checkpoint 1: re-score, calibration estimate after 6 mocks
3 (Dec 2026)	Discovery and product design	Project 1 (metrics audit); story bank drafted with numbers; first product-design drills	
4 (Jan 2027)	Analytics and diagnosis	Statistics and metric-diagnosis drills; Project 2 (a small analysis or experiment)	Checkpoint 2
5 (Feb 2027)	Experiments, improvement, critique	Project 2 readout; three teardowns with sources (C28 as models)	
6 (Mar 2027)	Execution and partnership	Project 3 (a spec with non-goals, reviewed by an engineer); first company briefs for three targets (C33)	Checkpoint 3; first practice applications (wave 0 to 1)
7 (Apr 2027)	Strategy and technical fluency	System-design and strategy drills; platform and ecosystem examples	
8 (May 2027)	AI product management	Evaluation-design and autonomy-ladder drills; an AI-feature spec with an evaluation plan	Checkpoint 4
9 (Jun 2027)	Behavioral, communication and loops	Stories polished and probed; Project 6 (an influence story); company briefs final	First full mock loop
10 (Jul 2027)	Mock loops and the gate	Three full mock loops with outside scoring; targeted drills	Readiness gate test 1 (FW-C37-06)
11 (Aug 2027)	Gap closure and applications	Drills on the remaining gaps; apply to top targets as the gate passes	Checkpoint 5; applications (wave 2)
12 (Sep 2027)	Peak readiness and fallback	The final-week protocol (C34.10) before each loop; the fallback plan decided (FW-C37-08)	Gate re-test before each loop

Application waves. Inferred: many early-career programs recruit on an annual cycle with a fall window, and direct associate roles are posted through the year [V: Google's and Meta's own pages: annual application windows], so the dates of your top-choice applications matter. Use three waves.

- *Wave 0 (months 1 to 3):* a few fit-checked roles where a miss costs little, to learn the process and get real feedback. Do not use your top-choice company here.
- *Wave 1 (months 6 to 8):* mid-priority targets once checkpoint 3 shows the high-weight dimensions near Strong.
- *Wave 2 (months 9 to 12):* top targets, only after the readiness gate passes.

An October 2026 decision. As of this writing, Google's 2027-start window has closed (6 October 2026) and Meta's program, though open, lists a four-year experience minimum, so this decision applies to other programs' windows and, for those two, to the next cycle. If you are eligible for a program whose window closes in October 2026 and it is your top target, decide in the first week using your baseline: apply if your outside-scored average on the high-weight dimensions is at least about 3.5 and you can complete a last-week protocol before a loop; otherwise plan for the next cycle and use this window's postings as practice for roles where you are eligible. This is an exception to the waves below: it spends a once-a-year window on your top target before the readiness gate has been passed, so accept it only knowingly. Ask the recruiter how reapplication works, because policies differ and I could not verify them [unverified: reapplication policies not found on the pages read]. Do not understate your experience or dates to fit a window (C01.5).

Counterexample. Asked how they prepared, a candidate says: "I read two books and did a lot of practice questions." The interviewer asks what the candidate's weakest area was and how they knew. The candidate has an activity list and no baseline, no measure of weakness and no evidence of change. A better answer: "My first three outside-scored mocks averaged 2.9 on analytics against 3.8 on product sense, so I put the largest share of drill hours there; after four months and 20 scored mocks, my analytics average was 3.9 and my self-scores matched the outside scorer within half a point."

When not to follow the plan as written. If your hours, dates or targets differ, change the plan but keep its structure: baseline, gap-driven hours, outside scoring, checkpoints, a gate. Do not delay applications indefinitely: a gate is a decision rule, not a reason to wait for perfection, and one loop is one draw from a selective process (C01.7).

C37.3 Weekly cadence and practice habits

A week of nine hours (adjust the block lengths, not the proportions) (FW-C37-03):

Block	Hours	What happens
Study	2.0	Read one part of the chapter on your path, then recompute its worked examples by hand, closed-book first

Block	Hours	What happens
Timed drills	2.5	Two or three exercises or questions aloud on the clock, from the week's target dimension (C34.6)
Partner mock	1.5	One scored mock with an outside scorer; record it; score independently before the debrief
Project	1.5	Progress on the current story project (C37.4)
Literacy	1.0	The weekly routine in C37.5
Journal and review	0.5	Update the error log and answer journal; schedule the retest of one fix

Habits that make it work.

- **Produce answers; do not reread.** Retrieval practice beat rereading in the study behind CS-C34-02; feeling fluent after rereading is not evidence.
- **Space the repeats.** Redo a missed drill after a day, a week and a month rather than five times in one evening; spaced practice is widely reported to improve retention [V: Cepeda et al., Psychological Bulletin, 2006].
- **One fix at a time.** Each week choose one error from the log and drill it (FW-C34-04).
- **Same time, same place.** A fixed slot makes the habit cheap.
- **One rest day, and a rest week every quarter.** Four of the 52 weeks are rest; plan them.
- **Protect sleep before a loop.** C34.10 covers the final week.

Regional Lens: India. Loops with teams in other time zones are commonly held remotely, which can place interviews late in the evening or early in the morning in India Inferred [unverified: author's synthesis; no source checked]. When you schedule a loop, ask for times in your time zone, plan sleep around them, run your mocks at similar hours at least twice, and test your connection and equipment in advance (C34.10). Also re-read the location and work-authorization lines of every posting (C01.4).

C37.4 Projects that become interview stories

A story needs a decision, an action, a result and a number (C31); the only reliable way to have many is to do work that produces them. The projects below fit a product job or, if you lack access to product data, a public dataset or a side product. Every story must be true: record the real numbers, credit the people who helped, and do not describe a sandbox exercise as work you did in a company (FW-C37-04).

#	Project	Months	Deliverable	Story it yields	Numbers to capture
1	A metrics audit of your product: define five metrics with owners and guardrails; find one that misleads	3	A one-page metrics card per metric and a finding	"I found that our headline metric rose while retention was flat" (C05, C29)	The metric's definition, the gap, the decision it changed
2	A small analysis or experiment: a funnel breakdown, a cohort comparison or a simple test	4 to 5	A readout with an interval and a decision	"I diagnosed a drop and recommended X" (C13, C14)	Sample, effect, interval, what shipped
3	A spec for a small improvement with non-goals and acceptance criteria, reviewed by an engineer	6	The spec and the review comments	"I wrote a spec that engineering built from" (C16)	Review changes, scope cut, delivery date
4	An analytics sandbox: load a public dataset and answer three product questions in SQL	2 to 4	The queries, the outputs and a one-page conclusion	Data fluency, not a work story (say so) (C37.6)	Rows, the three results, one caveat
5	A sourced teardown of a product with a tested change (a survey, a prototype test)	5 to 7	A labeled teardown and a test result	"I tested a change with five users" (C28)	Sources, test size, result
6	An influence project: get a decision made across functions	8 to 9	A decision document and the outcome	"I got a decision through without authority" (C32)	The stakeholders, the objection, the result

Guidance. Start the first project in month 2 so that by month 6 you have at least four stories with numbers. If your job offers no way to do projects 1, 2, 3 and 6, ask your manager for a small scoped piece of one; a request to learn is easy to grant. Projects take about 1.5 hours a week; a story that needs more time is too big, so shrink it.

C37.5 Industry and company literacy habit: sources and weekly cadence

Interviewers expect you to know the company's products and strategy at a level you can discuss with evidence. The habit is one hour a week, built on primary sources (FW-C37-05).

The weekly routine (60 minutes).

1. *Scan (20 minutes):* the official newsrooms of two or three target companies for product launches and changes.
2. *Read one primary document (25 minutes):* a shareholder letter, a filing section, a launch post or a published study, noting three facts with the source and date.
3. *Apply (15 minutes):* write five lines on one launch: who it is for, what you would measure, one risk and one question you would ask the team (the "what would you measure" drill, C28).

Verified sources. The sources below were confirmed as existing official pages in the research for this book; confirm they are current before relying on them [as of 2026-10].

Source	What to use it for	Status
Google: The Keyword (blog.google), the company's central official blog	Product announcements and leaders' posts	Verified existing in research for this chapter
Meta: Newsroom (about.fb.com/news)	Product and policy announcements	Verified existing in research for this chapter
Microsoft: The Official Microsoft Blog (blogs.microsoft.com)	Company and product news	Verified existing in research for this chapter (older post read; check the current layout)
Apple: Newsroom (apple.com/newsroom)	Product announcements	Verified in research for C28
Netflix: quarterly shareholder letters filed with the SEC, and the company's newsroom	Strategy and metrics, in the company's own words	Verified in research for C28
Airbnb: newsroom (news.airbnb.com)	Product releases and rationale	Verified in research for C28
Duolingo: annual report, registration statement and investor site	A model of how a public product company reports metrics	Verified in research for C28
Amazon: Leadership Principles page on its careers site (amazon.jobs)	The behavioral lens (C31)	Read for C31
SEC filings (EDGAR) for any public company	Registration statements and annual reports	Used for several cases in this book
Stripe: documentation and company pages	Developer-product questions	Not verified; check before use
Government service-delivery pages (for example a UK department's service-assessment page)	Phase models for products (CS-C30-02)	Verified existing in research for C30

What not to rely on. Preparation sites and forums are secondary and often outdated; use them to generate questions to check against a primary source, never as the source of a fact you will state (C28, FW-C28-02). Label anything you cannot source as an inference when you speak.

Turn it into company briefs. Each month, update the one-page brief for each target (C33.10): products, strategy signals with dates, three recent launches, a question for the team and the interview format as of that month. A brief with dated sources is evidence that you did the work.

C37.6 Practice toolkit and knowledge management: recording, note-taking, an analytics sandbox

Recording. A phone voice or video recording, reviewed within 24 hours, with a timer visible; score it against the anchors before anyone else does (C34.1). Keep recordings from month 1 so that you can hear your own progress.

Note-taking: five files. (1) `story-bank`: one entry per episode with decision, action, result and number, and the probes you have prepared (C31.5). (2) `error-log`: the date, the round, the error, the fix and the retest date (FW-C34-04). (3) `journal`: the weekly answer journal. (4) `briefs`: one page per target company. (5) `sandbox`: the queries and outputs. Plain text or any notes tool is enough; what matters is that each file has one purpose, is dated and is searched before every mock.

Spaced review. Tag every missed drill with a retest date: a day, a week, a month later. A simple weekly list of "due retests" is the whole system.

An analytics sandbox. Data fluency is a skill you can practice alone. SQLite ships with Python's standard library, so a laptop is enough; free open-source engines such as DuckDB are an alternative [V: Checked directly: `import sqlite3` works in a stock Python install (standard library path); DuckDB project README: open-source, in-process, MIT license]. The steps: load a public dataset (or generate one, as in Worked example 3), then answer three product questions: a funnel (how many users reach each step), a cohort retention (who returns), and a segment comparison (does a channel differ). For each, write the query, read the output, state one caveat (a small sample, survivorship, a definition problem) and one decision it would inform. Worked example 3 runs a complete example on synthetic data. The query patterns, the traps to avoid and the checks to run are in C13.6a (reading a query is in C21.4); C13.6a uses the same practice dataset and a second one for a mix shift (C13 Worked example 7).

Privacy and honesty. Do not paste confidential employer data, customer data or non-public company documents into practice tools, including AI practice partners (C34.9). Use synthetic or public data, and label sandbox work as such in an interview.

C37.7 The readiness checklist and the readiness gate

A **readiness gate** is a written decision rule, set in advance, that says when you apply to your top targets: a list of measurable conditions that must all be true, with a re-test before each loop. It replaces two bad deciders: anxiety ("not yet") and the calendar ("it's time") (FW-C37-06). The thresholds are the author's heuristics built on the C34 scorecard and calibration, not any company's rubric `Original` `Inferred`.

#	Condition	Threshold to pass
1	Outside-scored mocks (the last six)	Average at least 4.0 on each high-weight competency (product sense, problem solving, analytics, execution, behavioral); at least 3.5 on the others; no single score of 2 or lower on a dimension central to a round in the last three mocks
2	Calibration	Bias within ± 0.5 and error at most 0.75 over at least six mocks (FW-C34-03)
3	Full loops	Three full mock loops in the last six weeks, with an independent overall lean of "lean hire" or better in at least two
4	Story bank	Eight to ten stories with numbers; each survives two probes and a "what would you do differently" (C31)
5	Company briefs	A dated brief for each target, with the interview format as of this month and a tailored "why us"

#	Condition	Threshold to pass
6	Time and numbers	Estimation and metric answers completed in time with a stated number in at least four of the last five drills
7	Logistics and nerves	The final-week protocol rehearsed once; a plan for a bad round (C34.8)
8	Fallback	A written fallback plan (FW-C37-08)

If one condition fails, hold the applications to top targets (wave 2) for a defined period, drill the specific gap, and re-test; keep applying to lower-stakes roles (wave 0 and 1) meanwhile.

The fallback plan (FW-C37-08). Decide in advance what you will do if the gate is not met by month 11 or if you have not received an offer by a stated date:

1. *Diagnose from evidence:* compare actual interview feedback (where you were rejected, in which round type) with mock scores; look for a pattern.
2. *Widen the portfolio:* a loop is one draw from a selective process (C01.7); apply to more roles that fit (direct associate roles, internal transfers, smaller companies).
3. *Change one thing:* the weakest dimension, the round type where you fail, or the targets.
4. *Set the next date:* a re-test of the gate and a new application window; keep the habits and projects going.
5. *Protect yourself:* a rejection is data on one loop, not on you (C34.8).

C37.8 If you get the offer: your first 90 days

The same habits that got you the offer (a diagnostic baseline, outside feedback, small shipped work with numbers) are the first 90 days of the job (FW-C37-07). This is the concrete core of the "landing and thriving" material that Volume 2 will extend; it stays at the APM level and is Inferred from general descriptions of the role (C01.1) [as of 2026-10] .

Days 1 to 30: learn the product and the system.

- *The product:* use it as a user for several hours; read support tickets and the last two quarters of roadmap and launch reviews.
- *The system:* map the team's decision rights (FW-C01-01), the partners (FW-C01-02) and the planning rhythm.
- *The data:* find the team's metrics, how each is defined and what moved last quarter; run one query or read one dashboard yourself.
- *The people:* a 30-minute one-to-one with each partner (engineering, design, data, support, legal) with the same questions: what do you need from a PM, what has gone well and badly, and what should I know that is not written down?
- *Your manager:* agree what success looks like at 30, 60 and 90 days, in writing, and a weekly 30-minute check-in.
- *Output:* a one-page summary of what you learned, with questions, shared with your manager by day 30.

Days 31 to 60: build relationships and contribute.

- Own one small thing: a metric definition, a recurring report or a bug backlog review.
- Talk to users: at least ten conversations by day 60 (C06).
- Write one document that helps others: a decision document or a spec for a small change (C16, C32.2).
- Ask for feedback explicitly at day 45: one thing to keep, one to change.
- Earn credibility with engineering and design: ask for context, bring evidence, keep promises about dates and scope.

Days 61 to 90: ship one small thing well, and write down what you learned.

- Ship one small, low-risk change with a success criterion and a review date written before the build (C17, C29).
- Review it at day 90: what the metric did, what you would change.
- Write a retrospective: a pattern if one appears (C29), a practice you changed, and a plan for the next quarter, agreed with your manager.
- Update your own notes: the story bank for the job (the decisions, the numbers) so that the next promotion or move starts with evidence.

What APM-level performance looks like at day 90 *Inferred*. You can explain the product's users, metrics and decisions; your partners say you are reliable and clear; you have shipped one small thing with a measure; your manager has had your update every week; and you know the two or three things you do not yet understand. It does not look like having changed the strategy.

Common first-90-day mistakes. Proposing big changes before understanding the history; trying to prove yourself with a large idea instead of a small win; not asking for feedback until the formal review; treating relationships as optional; keeping quiet about confusion; and losing the notes of what you learned. Each has the same fix: small, early, measured and written down.

3. Frameworks

Eight frameworks, set out below. The importance-times-gap plan (FW-C01-04), the mock plan (FW-C34-01), the scorecard (FW-C34-02), the calibration check (FW-C34-03), the answer-journal loop (FW-C34-04), the drill library entry (FW-C34-05), the weakest-competency diagnosis (FW-C34-06), the story anatomy (FW-C31-03), the company brief (C33.10), the decision-rights map (FW-C01-01), the partner map (FW-C01-02) and the anti-pattern scan (FW-C29-01) are reused, not repeated.

FW-C37-01 · The diagnostic baseline · Original

- **Inputs:** three or more recorded mocks of different round types, each scored by an outside scorer on the C34 scale (1 to 5).

- **Outputs:** average scores by competency (unmeasured ones marked), importance times gap, drill hours by competency, a calibration estimate once six mocks exist, two numeric targets and a re-score date.
- **Assumptions:** the scorer uses the written anchors; three mocks are noisy.
- **Tradeoffs:** an early baseline is rough and sets the plan; a late one wastes months.
- **Failure modes:** self-scoring only; covering one round type; no targets.
- **Worked example:** Worked example 1.

Competency	Importance	Score	Gap	Importance × gap	Hours
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Formula: **hours for a competency = drill hours × (importance × gap) ÷ the sum of (importance × gap), where gap = 5 – score.**

FW-C37-02 · The twelve-month plan · Original

- **Inputs:** weekly hours, start and end dates, targets, and the baseline.
- **Outputs:** an hours budget by activity; the reading map with study hours by month; deliverables by month; checkpoints (re-scores and calibration) at months 2, 4, 6, 8 and 10; application waves; and the readiness gate with its re-test.
- **Assumptions:** nine hours a week for 48 weeks, adjusted to your life.
- **Tradeoffs:** a fixed structure resists drift and must bend when life changes; keep the structure and change the numbers.
- **Failure modes:** no checkpoints; hours not tied to gaps; applications by calendar.
- **Worked example:** Worked example 2.

FW-C37-03 · The weekly cadence · Original

- **Inputs:** your weekly hours.
- **Outputs:** blocks (study, timed drills, partner mock, project, literacy, journal) in the proportions 2.0 : 2.5 : 1.5 : 1.5 : 1.0 : 0.5, fixed times, one fix chosen from the error log and a rest rule (one rest day a week, four rest weeks a year).
- **Assumptions:** a fixed slot makes the habit cheap.
- **Tradeoffs:** a rigid week breaks on a bad day; protect the mock and the drill blocks first.
- **Failure modes:** rereading instead of producing; skipping the journal; no rest.
- **Worked example:** Worked example 2.

FW-C37-04 · The story-project card · Original

- **Inputs:** a candidate project.
- **Outputs:** the decision the project will force; the artifact; the numbers to capture (written before starting); the collaborators to credit; the time box (about 1.5 hours a week); and the story it yields, written in the C31 anatomy once finished, with an honest statement of what was sandbox and what was real.
- **Assumptions:** stories must be true and numbered.

- **Tradeoffs:** a small project yields a credible story sooner; a large one yields a vague one later.
- **Failure modes:** a project with no decision; numbers not captured; credit not shared.
- **Worked example:** the projects table in C37.4.

Project	Decision it forces	Artifact	Numbers to capture	Collaborators	Time box
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FW-C37-05 · The weekly literacy routine · Original

- **Inputs:** two or three target companies and a list of verified sources (C37.5).
- **Outputs:** a 60-minute routine (scan 20, read one primary document 25, apply 15), three dated facts with sources, five lines of "who, what to measure, one risk, one question," and a monthly update of the company brief.
- **Assumptions:** primary sources only for stated facts.
- **Tradeoffs:** a narrow set of sources is deep and misses news; add sources only after verifying them.
- **Failure modes:** forums as sources; facts without dates; no application step.
- **Worked example:** Worked example 3 (the "apply" step on a dataset) and EX-C37-06.

FW-C37-06 · The readiness gate · Original

- **Inputs:** the last six outside-scored mocks, the calibration estimate, three full mock loops, the story bank, the company briefs, the drills and the logistics.
- **Outputs:** pass or hold on eight conditions (C37.7), the failing conditions, a drill plan and a re-test date; the gate is re-tested before each loop.
- **Assumptions:** the thresholds are heuristics; the decision rule is written before the result.
- **Tradeoffs:** a strict gate delays applications and protects top choices; a loose gate burns them.
- **Failure modes:** moving the thresholds after a bad mock; ignoring calibration; waiting for perfection.
- **Worked example:** Worked example 4.

#	Condition	Threshold	Result	Pass or hold
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FW-C37-07 · The 30-60-90 plan · Original

- **Inputs:** your new team, manager and product.
- **Outputs:** goals and deliverables for days 1 to 30 (learn the product, the system, the data and the people; a one-page summary), 31 to 60 (own one small thing, ten user conversations, one helpful document, a feedback request) and 61 to 90 (ship one small change with a success criterion and a review date; a retrospective), agreed with the manager in writing, with a weekly check-in.
- **Assumptions:** the manager agrees the criteria at the start.

- **Tradeoffs:** a modest plan builds credibility; an ambitious one risks a miss.
- **Failure modes:** a plan of meetings; no shipped result; no written learning.
- **Worked example:** Worked example 5.

Period	Goals	Deliverables	Evidence
Days 1 to 30			
Days 31 to 60			
Days 61 to 90			

FW-C37-08 · The fallback plan · Original

- **Inputs:** the gate result, applications and outcomes, and feedback from loops.
- **Outputs:** a diagnosis (round type and dimension of failure), a wider portfolio, one change, a next date, and a protective routine; the probability of at least one offer as a function of the number of loops $(1 - (1 - p)^n)$ to set expectations.
- **Assumptions:** outcomes come from a selective process with real variance.
- **Tradeoffs:** a wider portfolio costs effort and raises the chance of an offer; narrowing for prestige lowers it.
- **Failure modes:** reading one rejection as a verdict; changing everything at once; stopping.
- **Worked example:** Worked example 6.

4. Answer architecture

The "how did you prepare, and what did you learn" answer, for two minutes

Step	Seconds	What to produce
The baseline	25	What you measured at the start, with a number
The plan	25	Where you put time and why
The evidence of change	40	A before-and-after number; a calibration or story result
What you learned about yourself	20	A pattern and a changed habit
The link to the job	10	How you will use the same loop on the team

Pacing rules. Keep to two minutes and expect "what was hardest?"; have a real answer with a number.

How to say it. "My first outside-scored mocks averaged 2.9 on analytics, so I put the largest share of drill hours there and re-scored every two months; it reached 3.9, and my self-scores came within half a point of the outside scorer's."

How to close. "I'd use the same loop on the team: a baseline, outside feedback and small shipped work."

Type: how do you keep up with the industry

The weekly routine, two named primary sources, one fact with a source and date, and one thing you did with it.

Type: how do you decide what to learn

Importance times gap; a baseline; a re-score date; one example of reallocating hours.

Type: what would you do in your first 30, 60, 90 days

The 30-60-90 structure with concrete deliverables, a measure and the manager agreement.

Type: tell me about a time you taught yourself something

The story anatomy with the baseline, the practice, the number, and the habit you kept.

Common interviewer interventions, and what to do

Interviewer says	What it means	What to do
"What was your weakest area?"	Honesty and evidence	Name it with a score and what you did
"How do you know you improved?"	Measurement	A before-and-after number and an outside scorer
"Why those sources?"	Source judgment	Primary, dated, and what you use each for
"What would you ship in 90 days?"	Realism	One small, low-risk change with a success criterion
"What if your manager gives no direction?"	Initiative	Propose your own plan and ask for corrections

5. Worked examples

Six worked examples. Examples 1, 2, 4, 5 and 6 are **Illustrative**: the people and figures are invented (invented), and the arithmetic was computed. Example 3 uses synthetic data generated by a script and quoted output (the data are invented, the output was produced by running the queries).

Worked example 1 — A baseline and an hours allocation (Illustrative)

The data (invented). At the end of month 2, after eight outside-scored mocks, a candidate's averages on the C34 scale are: product sense 3.8, discovery 3.2, problem solving 4.0, analytics 2.9, execution 3.5, technical 3.0, AI 2.6, design and UX 3.4, strategy and go-to-

market 3.1, behavioral 3.6. Importance (C01.6): 3 for product sense, problem solving, analytics, execution and behavioral; 2 for the others. The drill budget is 120 hours (FW-C37-01).

Compute. Importance $\times$ gap, with gap = 5 – score: product sense $3 \times 1.2 = 3.6$; discovery $2 \times 1.8 = 3.6$; problem solving $3 \times 1.0 = 3.0$; analytics $3 \times 2.1 = 6.3$; execution $3 \times 1.5 = 4.5$; technical $2 \times 2.0 = 4.0$; AI $2 \times 2.4 = 4.8$; design and UX $2 \times 1.6 = 3.2$; strategy $2 \times 1.9 = 3.8$; behavioral $3 \times 1.4 = 4.2$. The sum is 41.0. Hours ($120 \times \text{each} \div 41.0$): product sense 10.5; discovery 10.5; problem solving 8.8; analytics 18.4; execution 13.2; technical 11.7; AI 14.0; design and UX 9.4; strategy 11.1; behavioral 12.3.

Read it. Analytics is the largest allocation (18.4 hours) because it is both high in importance and the weakest score; AI (14.0) and execution (13.2) follow. Problem solving, the strongest score, gets the least (8.8) but still gets drills, to maintain it. The two numeric targets for the next checkpoint: analytics from 2.9 to 3.6 and AI from 2.6 to 3.3. Re-score at month 4 (checkpoint 2) and move hours as the gaps change.

What this shows. Eight scored mocks turned "I'm weak at stats" into an allocation of 120 hours with targets and a date.

Worked example 2 — Budgeting the year under three schedules (Illustrative)

The question (invented schedules). What changes if you have 6, 9 or 12 hours a week for 48 weeks (FW-C37-02, FW-C37-03)? The three schedules are assumptions (invented).

Compute. Hours in the year: 288, 432 and 576. In the proportions 2.0 : 2.5 : 1.5 : 1.5 : 1.0 : 0.5 (of 9):

Activity	6 h a week	9 h a week	12 h a week
Reading and worked examples	64	96	128
Timed drills	80	120	160
Partner mocks and scoring	48	72	96
Projects	48	72	96
Literacy	32	48	64
Journal and review	16	24	32
Total	288	432	576

Match to the reading map. The study cost of the tracks (twice the first-read time) is 69.3 hours for the core path, 24.4 for the deep dives and 12.5 for the reference library, about 106 hours in all. At 6 hours a week, the reading budget of 64 hours falls about 5 hours short of the core path (69.1): use the core path and cut a chapter or two by gap, and treat the deep dives by need. At 9 hours a week, the budget (96) covers the core path and the deep dives (93.5) and part of the reference library; the full map needs about 106, so choose the

reference chapters you use. At 12 hours a week, the extra reading hours (128) allow rereading problem areas, but retrieval practice is better than rereading (C34), so put the extra hours into drills and mocks instead.

Weekly rule. Protect the partner mock and the timed drills first; if a week is short, cut study, not mocks.

What this shows. One proportional budget scaled to three lives and showed which part of the book each schedule can afford.

Worked example 3 — An analytics sandbox on synthetic data (Reconstructed output)

The setup (FW-C37-05, C37.6). A script (Appendix B, script 1) generated a synthetic product dataset in SQLite: 5,000 users who signed up over 21 days from January 2027, each with a channel (organic, paid or referral), and events (signup, activated, returned, purchased). The data are invented; the figures below are the actual output of the queries.

Query 1: the funnel.

```
SELECT
  COUNT(DISTINCT CASE WHEN event='signup' THEN user_id END) AS signed_up,
  COUNT(DISTINCT CASE WHEN event='activated' THEN user_id END) AS activated,
  COUNT(DISTINCT CASE WHEN event='purchased' THEN user_id END) AS purchased
FROM events;
```

Output: 5,000 signed up; 2,574 activated (51.5% of signups); 530 purchased (10.6% of signups; 20.6% of activated users).

Query 2: by channel. The query joins `users` to distinct activated and returned users and groups by channel (a LEFT JOIN on a de-duplicated subquery for each event, so each user counts once).

Channel	Signups	Activated	Activation	Returned within 7 to 13 days	Return rate
Organic	2,248	1,208	53.7%	365	16.2%
Paid	1,745	699	40.1%	147	8.4%
Referral	1,007	667	66.2%	233	23.1%

Overall activation was 51.48% and the overall return rate 14.9% (745 of 5,000). Purchase rate by channel: referral 14.1%, organic 10.59%, paid 8.6%.

Read it. Paid brings 35% of signups (1,745 of 5,000) and has the lowest activation (40.1%), return (8.4%) and purchase (8.6%); referral is 20% of signups and has the best on all three. The overall average hides the difference (a mix effect: the share of paid users drags the overall rate). If acquisition costs were \$30 per paid signup and \$8 per referral signup (invented), the cost per purchaser would be $\$30 \div 0.086 = \text{about } \349 for paid and $\$8 \div 0.141 = \text{about } \57 for referral, so the channel economics diverge by more than six times.

One caveat and one decision. Caveat: the dataset is synthetic with built-in differences, so it shows how to read a channel table, not that paid channels perform worse; in real data, check sample sizes and definitions (what counts as "returned"), and survivorship (C12). Decision: it would justify testing a shift of some paid budget toward the referral program and examining why paid users do not activate (onboarding or targeting), with a guardrail on total signups.

What this shows. Three queries, with their output, practiced funnel, segment and mix reading, and the habit of stating a caveat and a decision.

Worked example 4 — Evaluating the readiness gate (Illustrative)

The data (invented). The last six outside-scored mocks (FW-C37-06):

Dimension	Mean of six	Lowest
Product sense	4.25	4.0
Problem solving	4.17	4.0
Analytics	3.75	3.5
Execution	3.92	3.5
Behavioral	4.33	4.0
Discovery	3.75	3.5
Technical	3.67	3.5
AI	3.42	3.0
Design and UX	3.83	3.5
Strategy	3.67	3.5

Calibration: the mean of the six differences between self and outside scores (bias) is +0.6; mean absolute error is 0.8. Three full mock loops in the last six weeks: overall leans of lean hire, lean no hire and lean hire.

Apply the gate. (1) Outside scores: analytics 3.75 (needs 4.0), execution 3.92 (needs 4.0) and AI 3.42 (needs 3.5): fail; no score of 2 or lower: pass. (2) Calibration: bias +0.6 exceeds 0.5 and error 0.8 exceeds 0.75: fail. (3) Full loops: two of three at lean hire or better: pass. Stories, briefs and logistics: assume pass. **Result: hold.**

The plan. Hold the applications to top targets for four weeks. Drill analytics and execution (the largest gaps in high-weight dimensions) and AI, add two more outside-scored mocks per week, apply a -0.6 correction to your own scores until bias is under 0.5, and re-test at week four. Keep applying to lower-stakes roles meanwhile.

What this shows. A written gate made the decision (hold, four weeks, these drills) from numbers, not from the feeling that the last mock went well.

Worked example 5 — A 30-60-90 plan for a new APM (Illustrative)

The setting (invented). An APM joins a team that owns onboarding in a consumer app: a manager, an engineering lead and five engineers, a designer, and a shared data scientist.

Days 1 to 30. *Product:* five hours as a new user, plus reading 60 support tickets and the last two quarters of launch reviews. *System:* the decision-rights map and the partner map (FW-C01-01, FW-C01-02). *Data:* find the five team metrics and their definitions; run one funnel query with the data scientist. *People:* a 30-minute one-to-one with each of six partners with three standard questions. *Manager:* a written 30-60-90 agreement and a weekly 30-minute check-in. *Output at day 30:* a one-page summary of what was learned, with five open questions.

Days 31 to 60. *Own one small thing:* the weekly onboarding funnel report. *Users:* ten conversations by day 60, notes in a shared file. *Document:* a one-page decision document proposing a fix for the step with the largest drop (from the funnel). *Feedback:* at day 45, ask the manager and the engineering lead for one thing to keep and one to change.

Days 61 to 90. *Ship one small thing:* a clearer explanation on the step (a copy and layout change), with the success criterion written before the build (completion of the step up by at least three points, with support contacts flat) and a review date four weeks after launch; released to 10% of users first (C17). *Review at day 90:* the result against the criterion. *Retrospective:* one page with a pattern, a practice and the next quarter's plan, agreed with the manager.

Measures (invented). By day 90: 6 one-to-ones done; 10 user conversations; 1 decision document accepted; 1 change shipped with a pre-written criterion; weekly manager updates delivered 12 of 13 weeks; the retrospective filed.

What this shows. A 90-day plan with concrete deliverables ends in a small shipped result with a measure and a written learning, which is what earns early credibility.

Worked example 6 — If the offers do not come: portfolio math and a diagnosis (Illustrative)

The data (invented). In months 9 to 12 a candidate sends 16 applications, gets 6 recruiter screens (37.5%), and reaches 3 full loops (50% of screens), with no offer yet.

Set expectations (FW-C37-08). Suppose each loop has a 20% chance of an offer (an assumption; selective processes reject most strong candidates, C01.7). The chance of at least one offer after n loops is $1 - 0.8^n$: after 1 loop, 20%; after 3, 48.8%; after 5, 67.2%; after 8, 83.2%; after 12, 93.1%. Three loops without an offer is therefore the expected outcome about half the time, not a verdict.

Diagnose from evidence. Compare the loop feedback with the mock scores: if all three loops ended at the analytics round, the pattern is analytics; if they ended at different rounds, the signal is noise. Suppose all three ended at an execution round (invented), where mock scores were 3.9. That points to a gap between mock and real conditions (for example, mocks that were easier than the real rounds), so tighten the mock realism (stricter timing, harder prompts, an outside interviewer from the target company's style).

Change one thing, set a date. Change the execution drills and the realism of mocks; widen the portfolio to eight more fit-checked roles (including direct associate roles and internal moves); set the next gate re-test in four weeks; keep the habits and projects going. After eight loops the chance of at least one offer rises to about 83% under the same assumption.

What this shows. Portfolio math reframed a run of rejections, the diagnosis found a likely cause, and one change with a date replaced a spiral.

6. Baseline, Strong, Standout

Prompt: "How did you prepare for this interview?"

Baseline answer

"I read a few books and watched videos on product management and practiced common questions with a friend. I think I'm well prepared."

What is wrong: an activity list; no baseline, measure or change; confidence without evidence.

Strong answer

"I planned the year. I started by recording three mock interviews and getting them scored, which showed analytics was my weakest area, so I put the most practice hours there and re-scored every two months. I built a story bank from real projects and practiced with two partners weekly. My analytics score went from 2.9 to 3.9."

Standout answer

Everything in the Strong answer, plus:

"I also measured how well I judge myself. After six mocks my self-scores ran 0.6 points above the outside scorer's, so I corrected for that and used the outside scores for decisions; by month ten the gap was under half a point. I set a written readiness gate before applying to top choices: averages of at least 4.0 on the high-weight dimensions, calibration within half a point and three full mock loops with an independent lean of hire or better. When the gate said hold, I held for four weeks and drilled the gap. I built six small projects into stories with numbers, such as a metrics audit that changed how we reported one headline number. I'd bring the same loop to the team: a baseline, outside feedback and small shipped work. The thing I learned about myself is that I overrate my fluency, so I rely on measurement."

What moves an answer up a band

From Baseline to Strong	From Strong to Standout
A baseline and a gap-driven plan	Calibration and a written gate
A before-and-after number	A self-knowledge finding that changed a habit
Stories from real work	Projects built into stories; the same loop applied to the job

7. Company lens

All claims describe what companies say publicly or what candidates commonly report, not insider knowledge [as of 2026-10].

Company lens: Google [as of 2026-10]. Google runs an Associate Product Manager program reported as two years with rotations and a fall window Inferred [unverified: candidate-reported]. Candidates commonly report structured, evidence-led rounds Inferred. Practical consequence: use the plan's gates to time your application and prepare estimation and design drills (C04, C07), and read the program's eligibility line before relying on it (C01.5).

Company lens: Meta [as of 2026-10]. Meta's Rotational Product Manager program is described on Meta's page as 18 months with three rotations, and as of October 2026 the posting dated 23 September 2026 shows the program open for March and September 2027 starts, lists four or more years of related industry or product management experience as a minimum qualification, and says applications open once a year, typically in late summer or early fall Public [V: Meta careers page and posting, indexed text, 8 October 2026]. Candidates commonly report analytical and leadership rounds Inferred. Practical consequence: read the posting's eligibility line first; if you meet it, prepare results-first stories and metric drills (C05, C13); if you do not, use the practice for programs you do qualify for.

Company lens: Microsoft [as of 2026-10]. Microsoft's published culture emphasizes a growth mindset Public [V: Microsoft careers culture page]. Candidates commonly report behavioral rounds on learning Inferred. Practical consequence: the preparation story in section 4, with its baseline and changed habit, fits this lens.

Company lens: Amazon [as of 2026-10]. Amazon publishes its Leadership Principles, including ownership and learning Public [V: Amazon's Leadership Principles, as cited by several summaries]. Candidates commonly report deep probing of stories and numbers Inferred. Practical consequence: use projects 1 to 6 to build true, numbered stories, and have each ready for three levels of probing (C31.7).

Company lens: Apple [as of 2026-10]. Apple publishes no hiring rubric, and hiring is reported to be team-specific Inferred [unverified: candidate-reported]. Practical consequence: tailor the literacy habit to the team's products through the newsroom and your own use, and prepare craft and restraint stories.

Company lens: Netflix [as of 2026-10]. Netflix publishes a culture document and shareholder letters Public [V: Netflix culture memo, June 2024; shareholder letters]. Candidates commonly report questions on judgment and candor Inferred. Practical consequence: read the letters as primary evidence (C28 Worked example 3), and include a story of feedback you acted on.

Company lens: Stripe [as of 2026-10]. Stripe is widely described as valuing clear writing Inferred [V: The Pragmatic Engineer, Inside Stripe's Engineering Culture Part 2 (strong culture of writing); Slab interview with Stripe's former Documentation Manager]. Candidates report written and rigor-focused questions Inferred. Practical consequence: include a written artifact (a spec or decision document) among your projects, and confirm Stripe's current loop format with the recruiter, since it was not confirmed in this book's research (C33).

8. Common mistakes

#	Mistake	How to detect it	Fix
1	Starting without a baseline	"I think I'm weak at metrics"	Three outside-scored mocks in two weeks
2	Practicing the favorite round	Flat scores in the weakest dimension	Importance times gap; re-score
3	Self-scoring only	Self-scores above outside scores	Outside scorer; calibration (bias, error)
4	Applying to the top choice first	A miss in month 2	Waves; the readiness gate
5	A gate moved after a bad mock	Thresholds change	Write the gate first; hold the rule
6	Rereading as practice	Chapters finished, scores flat	Produce answers on the clock; space retests
7	Stories without numbers	"It went well"	Projects that capture numbers from the start
8	Unsourced company claims	A fact with no source or date	Primary sources; dated briefs
9	No fallback	One rejection ends the plan	Portfolio math; diagnose; change one thing
10	A first-90-days plan of meetings	No shipped result	One small change with a pre-written criterion

9. Mental models applied

Four models, each tied to a decision in this chapter. [\[\[deliberate-practice\]\]](#) is from C34, [\[\[pareto-principle\]\]](#) from C15 and [\[\[inversion\]\]](#) from C02.

Deliberate practice ([MM-deliberate-practice](#), see [\[\[deliberate-practice\]\]](#), C34). Practice that targets a specific weakness with immediate feedback improves performance; repetition without feedback does not. The plan's drills, outside scorers and error log are this model made routine.

The Pareto principle ([MM-pareto](#), see [\[\[pareto-principle\]\]](#), C15). A few dimensions and gaps decide most of the loop outcome; importance times gap finds them.

Spacing ([MM-spacing](#)). Practice spread over time is generally retained better than the same practice crammed together, and the best gap between sessions grows with how long you need to remember [\[V: Cepeda et al., Psychological Bulletin 132\(3\), 354-380, 2006, a meta-analysis of spaced versus massed practice\]](#). Retests at a day, a week and a month use it.

Inversion ([MM-inversion](#), see [\[\[inversion\]\]](#), C02). Ask how the plan would fail: no baseline, no outside scoring, applying too early, no fallback, a first-90-days plan with no shipped result. Install a check for each.

Engineering, design and data-science perspectives

What your future partners expect from a new APM in the first 90 days, which is also what you can practice now.

- **Engineers** expect a clear problem, honest dates and context on users; they notice quickly whether you ask good questions and keep promises about scope. In your first month, ask each engineer what a PM does that wastes their time.
- **Designers and researchers** expect you to bring the user problem and evidence, not a solution; share your ten user conversations with them and ask to join their sessions.
- **Data scientists** expect a precise question and agreed metrics; run your first funnel query with them and define the metric together. Your sandbox practice shows here.
- **Your manager** expects the answer first, bad news early and a weekly update (C32); the written 30-60-90 agreement and the check-in are how you make that routine.

Checklist: before each month and before each loop

1. Do I have a current baseline and a re-score date?
2. Are my drill hours allocated by importance times gap?
3. Have I had an outside-scored mock this week?
4. Is my calibration (bias and error) known and shrinking?
5. Do I have a story with numbers from each completed project?

6. Are my company briefs dated and sourced from primary documents?
7. Has the readiness gate been re-tested before this application?
8. Is my fallback plan written?

10. Case studies

CS-C37-01 · The top choice in month two · Illustrative · Beginner

Fictional composite. Every number is invented (invented).

Situation. A candidate with about two years of product experience starts the plan in October. Excited by a posting for their top-choice company, and unsure whether another chance will come, they apply in the second week and, after a quick rehearsal, pass the recruiter screen.

Constraints. No baseline yet beyond one self-scored mock; a fixed date for the first round in three weeks; a top choice that the candidate has said they may not get another chance at; no understanding of how reapplication works.

Data. The first loop has four rounds. Outside scores from a practice partner who watched a recording of the candidate's rounds afterward (invented): product design 3.5, analytics 2.5, execution 3.0, behavioral 3.5. The loop ends after the analytics round with a polite rejection. The candidate's own self-scores had been 4.0, 3.5, 3.5 and 4.0 (a bias of about +0.75). The recruiter says reapplication is possible after 12 months (invented).

Problem definition. As an observable problem: "The candidate used their top-choice application before they had a baseline, a calibrated sense of their level or a readiness gate, and lost the cycle at a dimension they had not measured."

Analysis. The baseline would have shown analytics as the weakest dimension (2.5 against a gate of 4.0) and a bias of +0.75, both visible in the first month with two outside-scored mocks. The plan's waves (C37.2) and gate (C37.7) exist for exactly this: top targets are for after the gate passes, and lower-stakes applications provide practice. The cost of the early application is a 12-month wait (in this scenario), nearly the whole plan.

Options.

Option	Optimizes	Costs
A. Keep applying to top choices as postings appear	Perceived momentum	Burns the best targets before readiness
B. Run the baseline, apply first to wave 0 roles, use the gate for top choices, and plan the next cycle for the top choice	Readiness and learning	Slower start; a missed window for the top choice this cycle
C. Stop applying and prepare for twelve months	Safety	No real-world feedback

Tradeoffs. B costs a cycle on the top choice and protects it for the next; A feels like momentum and spent the chance; C removes learning from real loops.

Decision. Choose B for the future: withdraw nothing now, treat the first loop as data, write the gate before the next application, and start wave 0 roles for practice while drilling analytics; ask each recruiter about reapplication rules before applying.

Outcome. In this fictional scenario, the candidate's analytics average rose from 2.5 to 3.9 over six months with 18 outside-scored mocks; the gate passed in month ten; they applied again when the top-choice window reopened and reached the final round (invented).

Alternative outcomes. If the early loop had succeeded, the lesson is still that luck is not a plan; many candidates with a baseline and a gate would have the same offer with a lower risk. The lesson: measure first, keep top targets for after the gate, and use lower-stakes loops to learn.

11. Interview questions and model answers

Eight questions. Model answers are **Illustrative** (composite candidates), and every figure not taken from a cited public source is invented (invented). Each ends with follow-ups and answers. No company tag is attached because the topic is not tied to a single company.

IQ-C37-01 · Beginner · interview-craft · IC

Prompt. How do you keep up with this industry?

Rubric.

- **Baseline:** "I read tech news and follow people on social media."
- **Strong:** Names primary sources and a routine.
- **Standout:** Describes a weekly routine with primary sources, dated facts, an application step and a specific recent example, and says how it separates fact from inference.

Model answer. "I use a one-hour weekly routine built on primary sources. Twenty minutes scanning the official newsrooms of a few companies I follow, such as Google's Keyword blog and Meta's newsroom; twenty-five minutes reading one primary document in depth, such as a shareholder letter or a filing section; and fifteen minutes applying it: who a launch is for, what I would measure, one risk and one question. For example, Netflix's shareholder letter for the third quarter of 2023 said that membership in its ad-supported plan was up almost 70% over the previous quarter and that 30% of sign-ups in markets with the plan chose it [V: shareholder letter, October 2023]. What I took from it was that relative growth tells me nothing without the base and that I'd want to know whether those sign-ups were new demand or customers moving down from a higher-priced plan."

"I keep each fact with its source and date in a note, and I label anything I can't source as my inference, so that I don't present a guess as a fact."

Signals. Primary sources; a routine; a specific example; fact versus inference.

Follow-ups.

- **Q.** What do you do about news that comes from commentary and not the company? **A.** "I treat it as a lead: I look for the primary document that supports it before I rely on it, and if I can't find one I call it a rumor or an inference when I talk about it."
- **Q.** How do you decide which companies to follow? **A.** "By my targets and the products I use, so that I can compare what the company says with my own experience. I keep it to two or three so the habit stays at an hour."

IQ-C37-02 · Beginner · interview-craft · IC

Prompt. What would you do in your first 30 days as an associate product manager?

Rubric.

- **Baseline:** "Meet the team and learn the product."
- **Strong:** Names what to learn: users, metrics, partners, decisions.
- **Standout:** A concrete plan with deliverables, a written agreement with the manager, and a one-page output by day 30; says what it would not do.

Model answer. "I'd aim to learn how decisions get made and what the numbers say, not to change anything yet. In the first week I'd agree with my manager what success looks like at 30, 60 and 90 days, in writing, and set a weekly 30-minute check-in. I'd use the product as a user for several hours, read the support tickets and the last two quarters of launch reviews, and meet each partner for 30 minutes with the same questions: what do you need from a product manager, what has gone well and badly, and what should I know that isn't written down. I'd map the team's decision rights and the metrics and how each is defined, and run one funnel query with the data scientist."

"By day 30 I'd share a one-page summary of what I learned and what I still don't understand. I wouldn't propose a large change before I understand the history: a good early contribution is a small thing I own, such as a metric definition or a weekly report."

Signals. A concrete plan; the manager agreement; a day-30 output; restraint.

Follow-ups.

- **Q.** What if your manager gives no direction? **A.** "I'd write my own 30-60-90 plan, share it and ask for corrections. Most managers prefer a draft to an open question, and it shows initiative."
- **Q.** What is the biggest mistake new associates make? **A.** "Trying to prove themselves with a big idea before they understand the context. The small shipped win with a measure builds more credibility."

IQ-C37-03 · Intermediate · interview-craft · IC

Prompt. How did you prepare for this interview, and what did you learn about yourself?

Rubric.

- **Baseline:** "I practiced a lot and I feel ready."

- **Strong:** A baseline, a plan by gaps and a result.
- **Standout:** Outside scoring, a calibration finding, a written gate, a number for improvement, and a self-knowledge insight that changed a habit.

Model answer. "I started with a baseline: three recorded mocks scored by an outside scorer, which showed analytics as my weakest area at 2.9 against 3.8 on product sense. I allocated drill hours by importance times gap, so the biggest share went to analytics, and re-scored every two months. After six mocks I computed my bias: my self-scores ran about 0.6 above the outside scorer's, so I corrected for it and used outside scores for decisions. By month ten my analytics average was 3.9 and my bias was under half a point (invented).

"What I learned about myself is that I overrate how I sound; the recordings and the outside scores corrected that. I changed one habit as a result: I score before I hear anyone's feedback. I'd bring the same loop to the job: a baseline, outside feedback and small shipped work."

Signals. Baseline; gap-driven plan; calibration; evidence of change; a changed habit.

Follow-ups.

- **Q.** What was hardest? **A.** "Practicing the dimension I was weak at instead of the ones I was good at; it felt worse. I used the numbers to keep honest: the allocation came from the table, not my mood."
- **Q.** How did you know you were ready to apply? **A.** "I wrote a gate in advance: averages of at least 4.0 on high-weight dimensions, calibration within half a point and three full mock loops with an independent lean of hire or better. When it said hold, I held for four weeks."

IQ-C37-04 · Intermediate · behavioral · BE

Prompt. Tell me about a time you taught yourself something quickly.

Rubric.

- **Baseline:** "I learned SQL from videos."
- **Strong:** A goal, a method and a result.
- **Standout:** A baseline, a practice designed around feedback, a result with a number, honesty about what was a sandbox, and how the skill was used.

Model answer. *(A composite example; figures are invented.)* "I couldn't answer my own product questions without asking an analyst, which took two days. I decided to learn SQL well enough to answer funnel, retention and segment questions myself. I built a practice sandbox: a small synthetic dataset in SQLite, and I wrote three queries a week, each with a stated question, the output, one caveat and one decision it would inform. I asked the data scientist on my team to review one query a week.

"In six weeks my turnaround for a basic funnel question dropped from two days to under an hour, and in week five I found that one channel brought 35% of our signups with the lowest activation, which changed a test we were planning. I'm clear that the sandbox was practice; the real analysis used our data after the data scientist confirmed my definitions. I still ask for a review on anything that will drive a decision."

Signals. A baseline; a designed practice; a result with a number; honesty about practice versus real work.

Follow-ups.

- **Q.** What went wrong? **A.** "My first retention query counted a user multiple times because I joined without de-duplicating; the data scientist caught it. Since then I check the count of users against a known total before reading any percentage."
- **Q.** How did you decide it was enough? **A.** "When I could answer the three standard questions (funnel, cohort, segment) without help and explain the caveats; beyond that I rely on the data scientist for anything complex."

IQ-C37-05 · Intermediate · interview-craft · IC

Prompt. There is far too much to learn for this role. How do you decide what to learn first?

Rubric.

- **Baseline:** "The most important things first."
- **Strong:** Uses importance and gaps.
- **Standout:** Measures the gaps with outside scoring, weights by importance, allocates time proportionally, sets numeric targets, re-measures and reallocates, and keeps a minimum on strengths.

Model answer. "I measure before I choose. I take outside-scored practice results by competency, weight each by how much it matters for the role, and multiply by the gap to a target level: importance times gap. Then I allocate time in proportion. For example, with analytics at 2.9, AI at 2.6 and problem solving at 4.0, and weights of 3, 2 and 3, the products are 6.3, 4.8 and 3.0, so analytics and AI get most of the hours and problem solving a smaller maintenance share. I set a numeric target and a re-score date for the top two, and reallocate when the gaps change. I keep a minimum on strengths, because they decay without practice."

Signals. Measure then weight; proportional allocation; targets and re-scores.

Follow-ups.

- **Q.** What if the most important thing isn't measurable? **A.** "Then I define an observable proxy, such as a recorded answer scored against written anchors, or feedback from a partner, and I say it's a proxy. An imperfect measure beats a feeling."
- **Q.** What if priorities change, such as a new target company? **A.** "I re-weight importance for that company's loop (C33), re-run the allocation and adjust the hours; the structure stays the same."

IQ-C37-06 · Intermediate · execution · EX

Prompt. What would you ship in your first 90 days, and how would you know it worked?

Rubric.

- **Baseline:** "A small feature."

- **Strong:** A small change with a metric.
- **Standout:** A small, low-risk change chosen from evidence, a success criterion and review date written before the build, a staged release, and a retrospective.

Model answer. "I'd pick a small, low-risk change chosen from what I learned in the first 60 days, for example the step with the largest drop in the onboarding funnel. Say it's a clearer explanation on a permissions step, where 38% of new users drop. I'd write the success criterion before building: completion up by at least three points, with support contacts flat as a guardrail, reviewed four weeks after launch. I'd release to 10% of users first with a rollback trigger (C17).

"At day 90 I'd review the result against the criterion and write a one-page retrospective: what the metric did, what I'd change, and the plan for the next quarter, agreed with my manager. If it didn't move, I'd say so and say what I learned; a small measured change that failed still builds credibility."

Signals. Evidence-chosen change; criterion first; staged release; a retrospective.

Follow-ups.

- **Q.** What if engineering can't fit it? **A.** "I'd shrink it: a copy change or configuration might fit, or move it to the next cycle and ship something even smaller. The goal at 90 days is one small result with a measure, not the biggest idea."
- **Q.** What if the metric does not move? **A.** "I'd check whether it reached the users who need it and whether the measurement was sound, then decide to iterate once or stop; I'd tell my manager early and record the learning."

IQ-C37-07 · Hard · behavioral · BE

Prompt. Three weeks into the job your manager is very busy and gives you no direction. What do you do?

Rubric.

- **Baseline:** "I'd wait for direction," or "I'd start building something."
- **Strong:** Proposes a plan and asks for feedback.
- **Standout:** Writes a 30-60-90 draft, makes asking cheap for the manager, uses peers and documents to learn, delivers a small win, and keeps the manager informed on a fixed rhythm.

Model answer. "I'd make it easy for my manager to give direction. I'd write a draft 30-60-90 plan with what I intend to learn, own and ship, send it with three specific questions, and ask for a 20-minute slot to correct it. Meanwhile I'd learn from other sources: peer product managers, the launch reviews and metrics, the partners' one-to-ones. I'd pick one small thing to own and deliver it, so that I'm useful while direction forms. I'd send a four-line weekly update (done, next, blockers, one ask) so my manager can see progress with a minute's reading, and say plainly when I need a decision."

"If after another two weeks there's still no direction, I'd name it directly and kindly: 'I've been working from this plan; is this the right priority, or should I change it?' A manager who is busy usually responds well to a draft they can correct."

Signals. A draft plan; low-cost asks; learning from other sources; a small win; a weekly update.

Follow-ups.

- **Q.** What if the manager's silence continues for weeks? **A.** "I'd ask a skip-level or a trusted peer how the team handles direction, and keep delivering visible, small work. I'd also consider whether I'm asking in the right form: a decision with options is easier to answer than an open question."
- **Q.** What if you disagree with the priorities you were given? **A.** "I'd bring evidence and a proposal, not a complaint, ask for a decision, and then commit if the decision stands, noting the signal that would make me raise it again (C32.6)."

IQ-C37-08 · Hard · behavioral · BE

Prompt. After 90 days, how will you know whether you are performing at the level expected of an associate product manager, and what if you are not?

Rubric.

- **Baseline:** "My manager will tell me."
- **Strong:** Names indicators and asks for feedback.
- **Standout:** Defines indicators with the manager at the start, checks them at 30, 60 and 90 days with partner feedback, compares with evidence (a shipped change, reliable updates), diagnoses gaps early and makes a plan.

Model answer. "I'd agree indicators with my manager at the start, in writing, so that the standard is shared: for example, that I can explain the product's users, metrics and decisions; that I have shipped one small change with a measure; that partners find me reliable and clear; and that my updates are on time. I'd check them myself at 30, 60 and 90 days against evidence, and ask for feedback at day 45 from my manager and two partners: one thing to keep and one to change.

"If I'm behind on one, I'd say so early and make a specific plan: if I haven't shipped, I'd shrink the work; if a partner finds me unreliable, I'd look at dates and scope promises I've made and fix the process. I'd also check my own calibration: if my read of how I'm doing differs from my manager's by more than a little, I'd ask for examples. The aim is to find out at day 45, not at the review."

Signals. Agreed indicators; evidence; early feedback; a plan; calibration.

Follow-ups.

- **Q.** What if you disagree with your manager's assessment? **A.** "I'd ask for specific examples and the standard they're using, share my evidence, and look for where we see

different things. If we still differ, I'd ask what would change their view and make that my goal for the next month."

- **Q.** How do you handle imposter feelings? **A.** "I treat them as a signal to look at evidence: a log of what I've shipped and learned, and feedback from partners. I also ask peers how they started; most people recognize the feeling, and it fades as the evidence builds."

12. Exercises

Eight exercises. Each has a model solution and an alternative. Figures are invented unless stated.

EX-C37-01 · A baseline allocation

Problem. Outside-scored averages (1 to 5): product sense 3.5, discovery 2.8, problem solving 3.2, analytics 3.4, execution 3.0, technical 3.6, AI 2.4, design and UX 3.9, strategy 3.3, behavioral 3.0. Importance: 3 for product sense, problem solving, analytics, execution and behavioral; 2 for the others. Allocate 90 drill hours and name the top two targets.

Context. The baseline (FW-C37-01).

Data. As above.

Constraints. Eight minutes.

Expected approach. FW-C37-01 and Worked example 1.

Solution. Importance $\times$ gap (gap = 5 – score): product sense $3 \times 1.5 = 4.5$; discovery $2 \times 2.2 = 4.4$; problem solving $3 \times 1.8 = 5.4$; analytics $3 \times 1.6 = 4.8$; execution $3 \times 2.0 = 6.0$; technical $2 \times 1.4 = 2.8$; AI $2 \times 2.6 = 5.2$; design and UX $2 \times 1.1 = 2.2$; strategy $2 \times 1.7 = 3.4$; behavioral $3 \times 2.0 = 6.0$. The sum is 44.7. Hours ($90 \times \text{each} \div 44.7$): product sense 9.1; discovery 8.9; problem solving 10.9; analytics 9.7; execution 12.1; technical 5.6; AI 10.5; design and UX 4.4; strategy 6.8; behavioral 12.1. The top two targets are execution and behavioral (12.1 hours each); problem solving (10.9) is third and AI (10.5) fourth; AI is the weakest raw score, so set a target for it too (2.4 to 3.2). Set numeric targets and a re-score date for each.

Alternative solution. Set a floor of 4 hours for every competency and scale the rest.

Tradeoffs. A formula guides and judgment adjusts for the company's weighting (C33).

EX-C37-02 · Budget your own year

Problem. You have 10 hours a week for 40 weeks. Allocate the hours in the plan's proportions and compare the reading budget with the 105.9 study hours of the full reading map. What do you cut?

Context. The twelve-month plan.

Data. Proportions 2.0 : 2.5 : 1.5 : 1.5 : 1.0 : 0.5 (of 9).

Constraints. Six minutes.

Expected approach. Worked example 2.

Solution. Total 400 hours. Reading and worked examples: $400 \times 2 \div 9 = 88.9$; drills 111.1; mocks 66.7; projects 66.7; literacy 44.4; journal 22.2. The reading budget (88.9) is 17.0 hours short of the full map (105.9). Cut by need, in this order: first the reference library (12.4 hours) except what your gaps require, then the deep dives that do not match your targets (for example C19 or C20 if your targets are consumer roles). Do not cut mocks or timed drills.

Alternative solution. Take the shortfall from rereading time you would have spent anyway, which retrieval practice replaces.

Tradeoffs. A shorter plan covers less; the loss is acceptable if the high-weight dimensions are covered.

EX-C37-03 · Evaluate the gate

Problem. Last six outside-scored mocks (means): product sense 4.1, problem solving 4.3, analytics 4.2, execution 4.0, behavioral 4.4; discovery 3.6, technical 3.4, AI 3.6, design and UX 3.9, strategy 3.5. Bias +0.4, error 0.7. Three full mock loops: leans of lean hire, lean hire, lean no hire. Apply the gate (C37.7) and say what you do.

Context. The readiness gate.

Data. As above.

Constraints. Six minutes.

Expected approach. FW-C37-06 and Worked example 4.

Solution. (1) High-weight dimensions are all at least 4.0 (execution is exactly 4.0): pass; others need at least 3.5: technical is 3.4: fail by 0.1. (2) Calibration: bias 0.4 (within ± 0.5) and error 0.7 (at most 0.75): pass. (3) Loops: two of three at lean hire or better: pass. Result: hold on one condition. Plan: two weeks of technical fluency drills (C21) with two more outside-scored mocks that include a technical question, then re-test; apply to wave 1 roles meanwhile. The margin is small, so avoid treating a 0.1 shortfall as a reason for a long delay: re-test quickly.

Alternative solution. Treat the condition as a "pass with watch" for the first loop if the target company's loop has little technical weight (C33), and say why in writing before you apply.

Tradeoffs. A strict gate protects top targets; a tiny shortfall should cost days, not months.

EX-C37-04 · A story-project card

Problem. Fill in the story-project card (FW-C37-04) for "a metrics audit of the product I work on," with the decision it forces, the artifact, the numbers to capture, collaborators, time box and the story it yields.

Context. Projects that become stories.

Data. None.

Constraints. Seven minutes.

Expected approach. FW-C37-04 and C37.4.

Solution. *Decision it forces:* which metric the team treats as its headline and what its guardrail is. *Artifact:* a one-page metric card (definition, owner, data source, guardrail) for five metrics, plus a finding. *Numbers to capture before starting:* the current value and trend of each metric; the share of decisions in the last quarter that cited each; for the finding, the gap (for example, the headline rose 9% while four-week retention was flat). *Collaborators:* the data scientist (definitions) and the engineering lead (instrumentation); credit them. *Time box:* 1.5 hours a week for four weeks. *Story:* "I audited our five core metrics, found that our headline measure counted accidental sessions, proposed a replacement with a guardrail, and we changed our weekly report" (C05, C29), written in the C31 anatomy once the result is known, stating which numbers are real.

Alternative solution. Choose the project whose decision your manager already cares about, so that the result is used.

Tradeoffs. A narrow audit yields a credible story sooner than a complete one.

EX-C37-05 · Read a channel table

Problem. A synthetic dataset gives: channel A, 3,000 signups, 1,500 activated, 450 returned; channel B, 2,000 signups, 600 activated, 120 returned. Write the SQL idea for the activation and return rates by channel, compute them, read them and state one caveat and one decision.

Context. The analytics sandbox.

Data. As above.

Constraints. Eight minutes.

Expected approach. Worked example 3.

Solution. *Idea:* join users to de-duplicated sets of activated users and returned users, group by channel, and divide the counts by signups (a LEFT JOIN on a distinct-user subquery for each event so that each user is counted once). *Compute:* A: activation $1,500 \div 3,000 = 50.0\%$, return $450 \div 3,000 = 15.0\%$; B: activation $600 \div 2,000 = 30.0\%$, return $120 \div 2,000 = 6.0\%$. *Read:* A converts better at both steps; overall activation is $(1,500 + 600) \div 5,000 = 42.0\%$ and return $(450 + 120) \div 5,000 = 11.4\%$, a blend that hides the gap. *Caveat:* check the definition of "returned" and the time window, and that each user is counted once. *Decision:* investigate why B does not activate (onboarding or targeting) before spending more on B, with a guardrail on total signups.

Alternative solution. Add the purchase rate by channel and the cost per purchaser using invented acquisition costs.

Tradeoffs. A synthetic example teaches the reading; real data needs definitions checked with the data scientist.

EX-C37-06 · One literacy session

Problem. Run the 60-minute routine (FW-C37-05) on one target company. Deliver three dated facts with sources, five lines of "who, what to measure, one risk, one question," and one change to your company brief.

Context. The weekly literacy habit.

Data. Primary sources from C37.5.

Constraints. Sixty minutes.

Expected approach. FW-C37-05.

Solution. A good deliverable: three facts, each with the source type, date and a link or title (for example, a shareholder letter's statement that an ad plan's membership rose almost 70% in a quarter, October 2023); five lines: *who it is for* (price-sensitive households), *what to measure* (net additions, mix of new versus downgraded sign-ups, revenue per member), *one risk* (cannibalization of the higher-priced plan), *one question* (what share of ad-plan members are new to the service), and an update to the brief (a dated line on the plan and its stated metrics). Label anything not in a source as your inference.

Alternative solution. Do it on a company whose letter or filing you have never read, to practice finding the right section quickly.

Tradeoffs. One company deeply beats five superficially.

EX-C37-07 · A 30-60-90 plan

Problem. You join a business-to-business product team that owns an admin console for an enterprise tool. Write a 30-60-90 plan (FW-C37-07) with goals, deliverables and evidence for each period, including one small shipped change with a success criterion and a review date.

Context. The first job.

Data. None.

Constraints. Ten minutes.

Expected approach. FW-C37-07 and Worked example 5.

Solution. *Days 1 to 30:* use the console as an administrator on a test account; read the last two quarters of support tickets and launch reviews; map decision rights and partners (including security and customer success); learn the five team metrics and one query; one-to-ones with partners; written plan agreed with the manager; a one-page summary at day 30. *Days 31 to 60:* own the weekly admin-usage report; ten calls with administrators, including two at large customers; a decision document proposing a fix for the most-cited support issue; feedback request at day 45. *Days 61 to 90:* ship one small change (for example, a bulk user-import error message that says what to fix), with the criterion written first (support tickets about import down by 25% in four weeks, with import completion flat or up) and the review at day 90, released to 10% of accounts first; a retrospective and a plan for the next quarter. Evidence: the summary, the calls log, the accepted document, the shipped change and its result.

Alternative solution. Shadow a customer success manager for a week to learn the administrator's day.

Tradeoffs. A small change in an enterprise setting may need more review; plan the security and customer-communication steps early.

EX-C37-08 · Portfolio math

Problem. Suppose each loop has a 15% chance of an offer (an assumption). Compute the probability of at least one offer after 1, 3, 6, 10 and 15 loops, and the number of loops needed for about 90%. What does it mean for the plan?

Context. The fallback plan.

Data. $P(\text{at least one}) = 1 - (1 - p)^n$.

Constraints. Five minutes.

Expected approach. FW-C37-08 and Worked example 6.

Solution. After 1 loop: 15%; 3 loops: 38.6%; 6: 62.3%; 10: 80.3%; 15: 91.3%. For 90%: $n = \ln(0.1) \div \ln(0.85) = \text{about } 14.2$, so about 15 loops. Meaning: with a per-loop chance this low, even a strong candidate should expect several loops before an offer; the plan's job is to raise p (through the gate) and to raise n (through a wide, fit-checked portfolio), and not to read three rejections as a verdict. The assumption of independence and a fixed p is rough; the point is the shape.

Alternative solution. Compute at $p = 25\%$: 3 loops 57.8%, 6 loops 82.2%; the number needed for 90% is about 8.

Tradeoffs. More applications cost effort and raise the chance; raising p costs preparation and also raises it.

13. Practice protocol

Timed drills (three a week for two weeks).

- *Week 1: baseline and plan.* Use IQ-C37-01, IQ-C37-03, IQ-C37-05, EX-C37-01, EX-C37-02 and EX-C37-04. Record three mocks, get them scored, and compute your own allocation and targets.
- *Week 2: gate, literacy and the first job.* Use IQ-C37-02, IQ-C37-04, IQ-C37-06 to IQ-C37-08, EX-C37-03, EX-C37-05 to EX-C37-08. Run one literacy session, write your gate and your fallback, and rehearse the two-minute preparation answer aloud.

With a partner. Ask your partner to say "How do you know you improved?" and "What was your weakest area?" at random, and to ask for the source and date of every company fact you state.

Feedback checklist (yes, partly, no).

1. Did I start from a measured baseline with a number?

2. Did I allocate hours by importance times gap?
3. Did I use outside scoring and know my calibration?
4. Did I give a before-and-after number?
5. Did I use primary, dated sources for company facts?
6. Did I name a written gate and a fallback?
7. Did my first-90-days answer include a shipped result with a criterion written first?
8. Did I say what I learned about myself and the habit it changed?

Answer journal. Record the date, the prompt, the number I could not produce, my score and the one fix; re-score monthly against the checkpoint targets.

14. Implementation playbook

Start the plan this week.

Days 1 to 3. Set up the toolkit (C37.6): a recording method, five notes files and the sandbox. Decide your weekly hours and your start and end dates. Check this week's postings against the fit check (C01.5) and decide your October-window question.

Week 1. Record three mocks of different round types and get an outside scorer (C34). Compute the baseline table and the allocation (FW-C37-01). Draft your story-bank list of ten episodes and pick your first project (FW-C37-04).

Week 2. Run the first literacy session (FW-C37-05) and write the first company brief. Write the readiness gate and the fallback plan on one page, dated, before you have any results.

Month 1 and after. Follow the monthly table in C37.2; re-score at each checkpoint; test the gate before every top-target application. If you get an offer, switch to the 30-60-90 plan (FW-C37-07) and keep the same loop: baseline, outside feedback and small shipped work.

Deliverables that become assets: the baseline and allocation, the dated gate and fallback, six project stories with numbers, the dated company briefs, the sandbox queries and outputs, and the weekly journal. Keep every claim about your experience true and dated.

15. Key takeaways and further reading

Key takeaways

1. Start from a measured baseline: outside-scored mocks on the C34 scale, averaged by competency, with importance times gap setting the hours and numeric targets set for the top two gaps.
2. Plan the year in months: about nine hours a week for 48 weeks (432 hours) split into study, timed drills, partner mocks, projects, literacy and review; follow the reading map (a core path of 21 chapters, eight deep dives and a five-chapter reference library, or the 80-hour fast track), re-score at five checkpoints and apply in waves.

3. Practice by producing answers with outside scoring, space the retests, fix one error at a time, and build projects into stories with numbers that are true.
4. Decide when to apply by a written readiness gate (scores, calibration, full loops, stories, briefs, logistics, fallback), hold top targets until it passes, and use portfolio math and a diagnosis, not a verdict, when offers do not come.
5. If you get the offer, run the same loop at work: learn the product and system in 30 days, own a small thing and talk to users by day 60, ship one small change with a criterion written first by day 90, and write down what you learned.

Further reading

- The official company pages named in C37.5, read as primary sources and dated [V: company pages named, checked as sources in October 2026] .
- Roediger and Karpicke (2006) on retrieval practice, the evidence behind CS-C34-02 [V: Roediger and Karpicke (2006)] .
- Cepeda, Pashler, Vul, Wixted and Rohrer, "Distributed Practice in Verbal Recall Tasks: A Review and Quantitative Synthesis," *Psychological Bulletin* 132(3), 354 to 380 (2006), a meta-analysis of the spacing evidence for verbal recall [V: Psychological Bulletin 132(3), 354 to 380, May 2006, doi 10.1037/0033-2909.132.3.354] .
- Chapters C01 (the role and the book), C31 (stories), C33 (loops and company lenses), C34 (mocks, scoring and calibration) and C16 and C32 (the first job) of this book.